Alabama, 310 U. S. 88, 101–102 (1940); see *Mills* v. *Alabama,* 384 U. S. 214, 218 (1966). In the mailing that triggered the regulation at issue, Consolidated Edison advocated the use of nuclear power. The Commission has limited the means by which Consolidated Edison may participate in the public debate on this question and other controversial issues of national interest and importance. Thus, the Commission's prohibition of discussion of controversial issues strikes at the heart of the freedom to speak.

III

The Commission's ban on bill inserts is not, of course, invalid merely because it imposes a limitation upon speech. See *First National Bank of Boston* v. *Bellotti, supra,* at 786. We must consider whether the State can demonstrate that its regulation is constitutionally permissible. The Commission's arguments require us to consider three theories that might justify the state action. We must determine whether the prohibition is (i) a reasonable time, place, or manner restriction, (ii) a permissible subject-matter regulation, or (iii) a narrowly tailored means of serving a compelling state interest.

A

This Court has recognized the validity of reasonable time, place, or manner regulations that serve a significant governmental interest and leave ample alternative channels for communication. See *Linmark Associates, Inc.* v. *Willingboro,* 431 U. S. 85, 93 (1977); *Virginia Pharmacy Board* v. *Virginia Citizens Consumer Council,* 425 U. S. 748, 771 (1976). See also *Kovacs* v. *Cooper,* 336 U. S. 77, 104 (1949) (Black, J., dissenting). In *Cox* v. *New Hampshire,* 312 U. S. 569 (1941), this Court upheld a licensing requirement for parades through city streets. The Court recognized that the regulation, which was based on time, place, or manner criteria, served the municipality's legitimate interests in regulating traffic, securing public order, and insuring that simultaneous parades did not pre-